

MONO STEREO

REVIEWING THE WORLD'S FINEST AUDIO PRODUCTS



Louis Desjardins is a unique high-end analog audio entrepreneur who, in just over a decade, has established himself as a major player in the field of analog reference front ends, winning many hearts and an impressive number of awards at high-end audio trade shows worldwide.

The main difference that makes the Kronos' overall analog experience so distinct from others is its unique way of delivering music, literally embodying the theorem of fluidity, transparency, and sonority.



Mono Stereo

The Discovery RS and the Kronoscope RS tonearm continue and significantly expand the legacy of the Black Beauty and Helena tonearms, the two new Kronos Audio tonearms are fundamentally different from the initial ones.



The Discovery RS, and the Kronoscope RS tonearm I previously reviewed has the same focus on the same positive sonic virtues (such as speed, spot-on tempi, timbre, and color) and music reproduction, and are cut from the same cloth, but the Discovery RS is distinctly different, and when combined with the Kronos Pro turntable, goes a step further.

Discovery RS

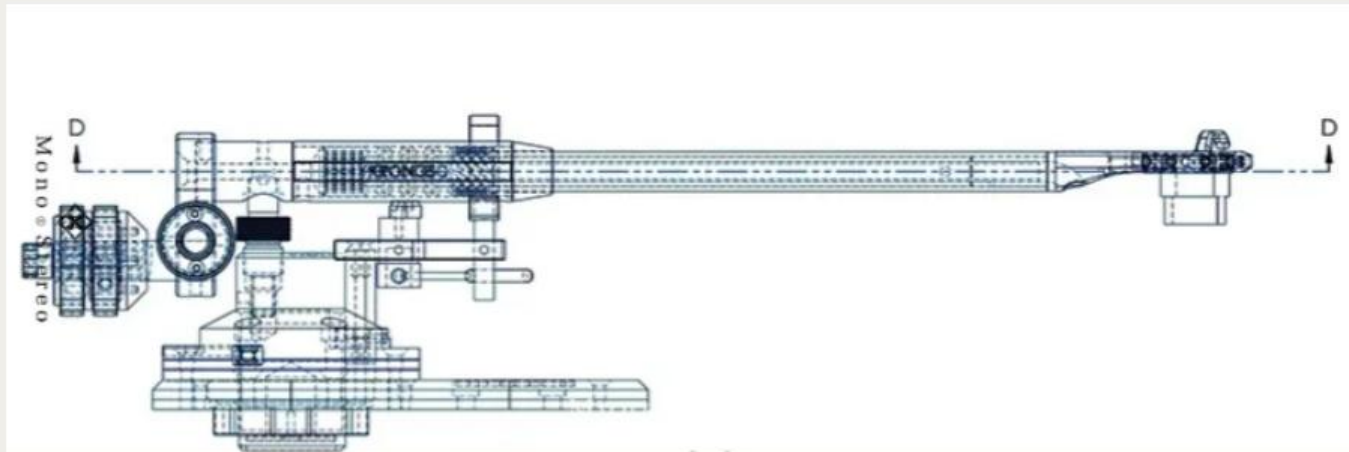
In the analog domain, where every nuance of sound counts, the Kronos Audio Discovery RS tonearm follows Desjardin's meticulous pursuit of sonic perfection, marked by precision and passion, at the same level as when embedded in turntables.



The Discovery RS has an effective length of 306 mm, a medium-high effective mass, an overhang of 13.2 mm, a pivot-to-spindle distance of 292 mm, a maximum tracking error of 0.125, and a measured resonant frequency of 6.5 hertz.

The Discovery's versatility allows compatibility with cartridges from 5 to 24 grams, enabling the selection of preferred

cartridges without compromise.



A proprietary bearing — a half ball and a surface-treated elliptical, dimpled uni-pivot receiving cup — ensures that records spin with precision and stability.

The VTA's coarse and fine adjustments allow for up to a full inch of adjustment, while the dual counterweight fine adjustment permits flawless alignment.



The RS tonearm tube features patented resonance suppression technology and latticed, multi-layer, grid-reinforced composite material, as well as a high-precision, nickel-plated lasered ceramic composite headshell. The combination of these two fundamental parts was designed to capture the essence of every note.





Beneath it all, is the cartridge plate, a 5-point adjustable variable resonance suppression assembly that opens up an impressive level of sonic fine-tuning.

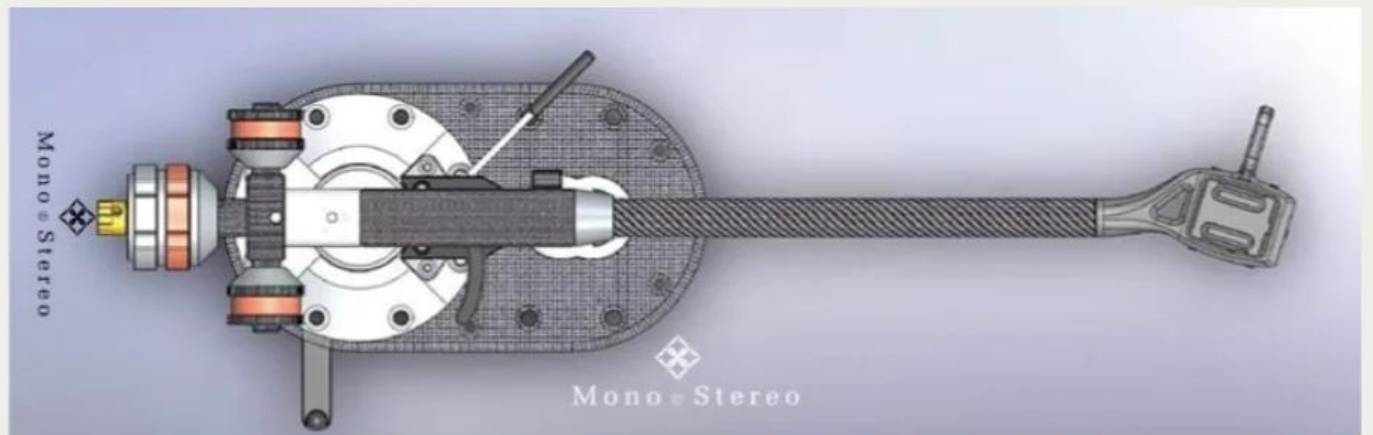
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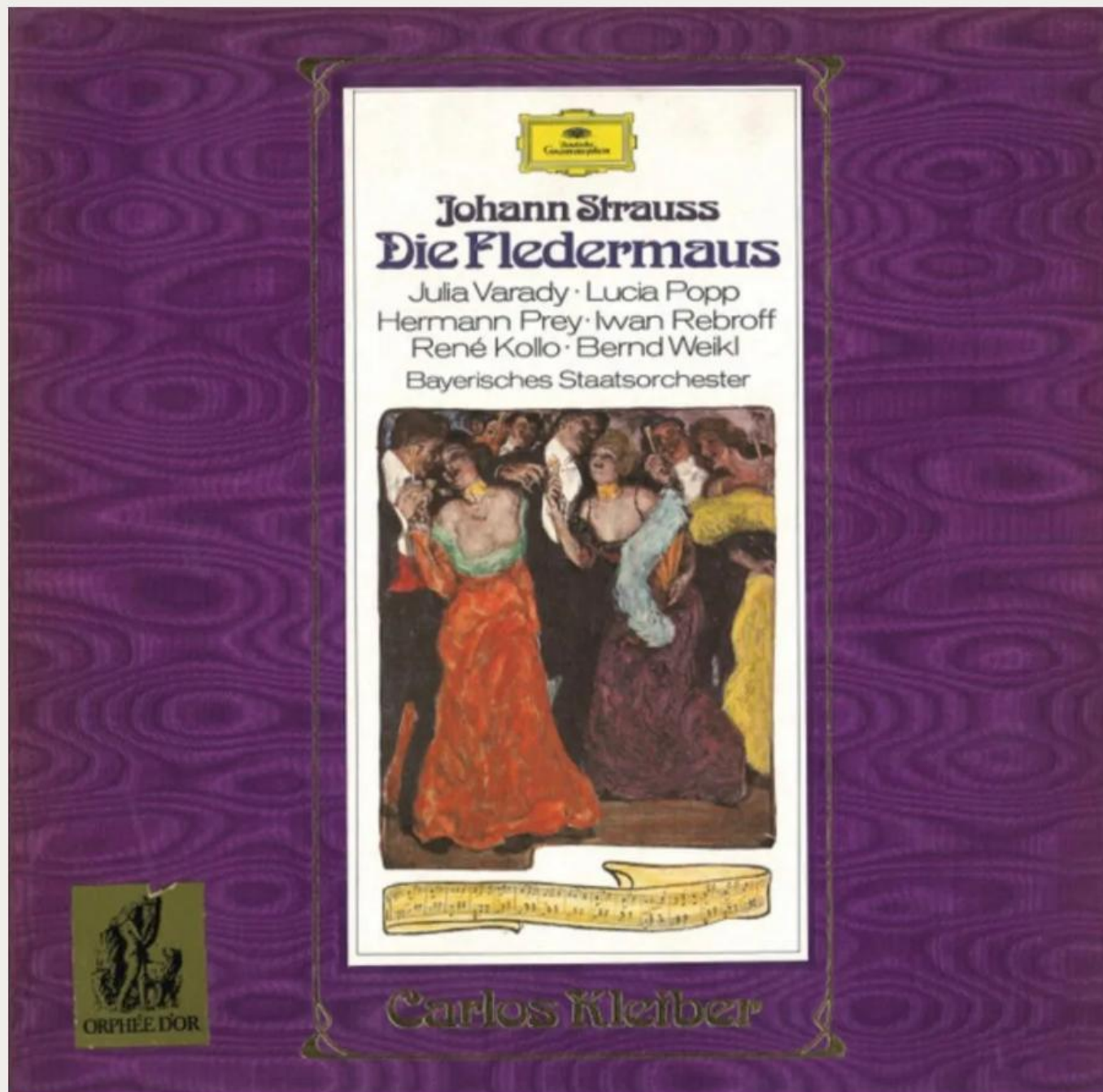
Like all Kronos Audio turntables, the Discovery RS is not just another piece of equipment. The flagship tonearm continues the story of craftsmanship, precision, and Desjardins' deep love of music, making it an objective, ultimate gateway to the world of Kronos Audio's analog universe.



The Music

From track to track, album to album, Kronos Audio Discovery RS tonearm acted encyclopedic, insightful, and inviting.

As always, here are a few examples of the virtues of the Discovery RS with music references.



Johann Strauss – Julia Varady, Lucia Popp, Hermann Prey, Iwan Rebroff, René Kollo, Bernd Weikl, Bavarian State Orchestra, Carlos Kleiber – Die Fledermaus

Carlos Kleiber's interpretation of Johann Strauss' opus magnum, *Die Fledermaus*, a symphonic masterpiece, is a marvel of tone, color, and featherlike orchestral momentum. The recorded orchestra sounds both lush and translucent, in the best way that accurately and intimately reflects reality, and the Kronos Audio Discovery RS tonearm painted *Die Fledermaus*' sonic tapestry with exceptional depth and richness.

The Discovery RS brought out the timbre, tone, color, and subtle nuances of instruments and vocal performance on the superbly recorded album with remarkable precision and alleviation.

With the given immediacy, the listener is transported into the heart of the music, always in sync with the orchestra, and on top of all these positive attributes, the Kronos Audio tonearm allows fine details to unfold with breathtaking realism.



The Mair-Davis Duo – Picaflor: Latin Music for Guitar and Mandolin

Picaflor by the Mair-Davis Duo represents one of the best recordings of acoustic guitar and mandolin, bordering on an eggshell if the analog front end and high-end audio system are set up properly.

The Discovery RS let the timbre of these instruments exude an unmistakable natural warmth and authenticity that immediately transports the listener into the enchanting world of Latin American musical traditions.

With the Discovery RS tonearm, the sound is masterfully balanced, with the acoustic guitar taking center stage in the first tracks on the Bs side and displaying a fascinating eerie sense of reality.

Kronos Audio's flagship tonearm captures and reflects the splendidly recorded instruments, acting as a paragon of factual delicacy that makes every pluck and strum ring out with remarkable transparency.

It was intriguing to observe how RS Discovery managed to deliver crisp highs without harshness, lifted mids and upper midrange without faux, and tight, focused bass without booming.

Everything gelled instantly, and blended seamlessly, creating a unique, captivating reproduction with a surprisingly natural flow to the music.



LaSalle Quartet, Schoenberg, Berg, Webern – Neue Wiener Schule – Die Streichquartette

The LaSalle Quartet's rendition of the seminal compositions of the Neue Wiener Schule is my reference album when it comes to how well the system or a particular component can capture the delicate intimacy of string instruments, atmospheric momentum, three-dimensionality and the expanse of the sonic sphere.

The particular soundness of Discovery RS tonearm brought out the true nature of LaSalle Quartet's captivating sonic odyssey, which, when everything is in tune, captures the listener's attention with every note that echoes in the listening room.

Proper reproduction of the Quartet is a challenge for any tonearm, but the Kronos Audio Discovery RS has shown an unwavering commitment to reproducing the essence of these avant-garde pieces with one-of-the-kind luminosity.

The top-of-the-line Kronos tonearm allows the timbre and tone of the strings to emerge with startling realism, providing a unique immersion into the complex yet beguilingly lyrical world of Schoenberg, Berg, and Webern, further solidifying its value and role in revealing profound musical qualities, with a ravishing rendering of the depth of the quartet's interpretation and the boundless subtleties within.



LA4 – Zaca

The Kronos Audio Discovery RS tonearm's remarkable ability to reveal a tiny universe at every point of musical connections continues with LA4's *Zaca*, a triumphant jazz fusion that is acclaimed by yours truly for its sonic intricacy musicians artistry.

Like all LA4 albums, *Zaca* is superbly recorded and always feels like a breath of fresh air with its purity, immediacy, and top-notch musical performance.

With ease, the Discovery RS derived from the grooves the sheer (and much-needed) music energy, and every note and improvisational momentum with dazzling clarity, reaching the sound core directly and making this jazz fusion gem shine in the best possible way.

The Discovery RS has not only given each instrument a distinctive voice and three-dimensional placement in the sonic orb but with its outstanding capabilities and uncompromising fidelity to the source, it has also reproduced artistic expression completely unbridled and unrestrained, which is a shining example from an audiophile perspective. Unfortunately, uncompromising decipherment and unriddling are something most tonearms struggle with regardless of price, which says a lot about the Kronos tonearm.

Conclusion

Desjardins has put a lot of time and effort into eliminating all kinds of micro-vibration and resonance, as evidenced by the elimination of vibration-causing torque force through the dual platter design, and the same dedication follows with the Kronos Audio Discovery RS tonearm.



Discovery RS was designed with the simple goal of not only being a definitive, full-featured Kronos product but also a matching partner for Kronos Audio turntables without breaking the spirit and staying in line with Kronos' renowned virtues like neutral frequency response, natural timbres, lightning-fast transients, and remarkable dynamics.



The Discovery RS continues what Kronos Pro turntables have already firmly established. Dechipripg and deriving music variety is a spice of any no-nonsense music reproduction. The Discovery RS goes beyond variety into the realm of verisimilitude by not being there in the way of the music, not altering tone, never sounding brash, and as often said in the studio terms, bringing the faders down so the music can be heard at a lower volume. Something that alone is worth highlighting.

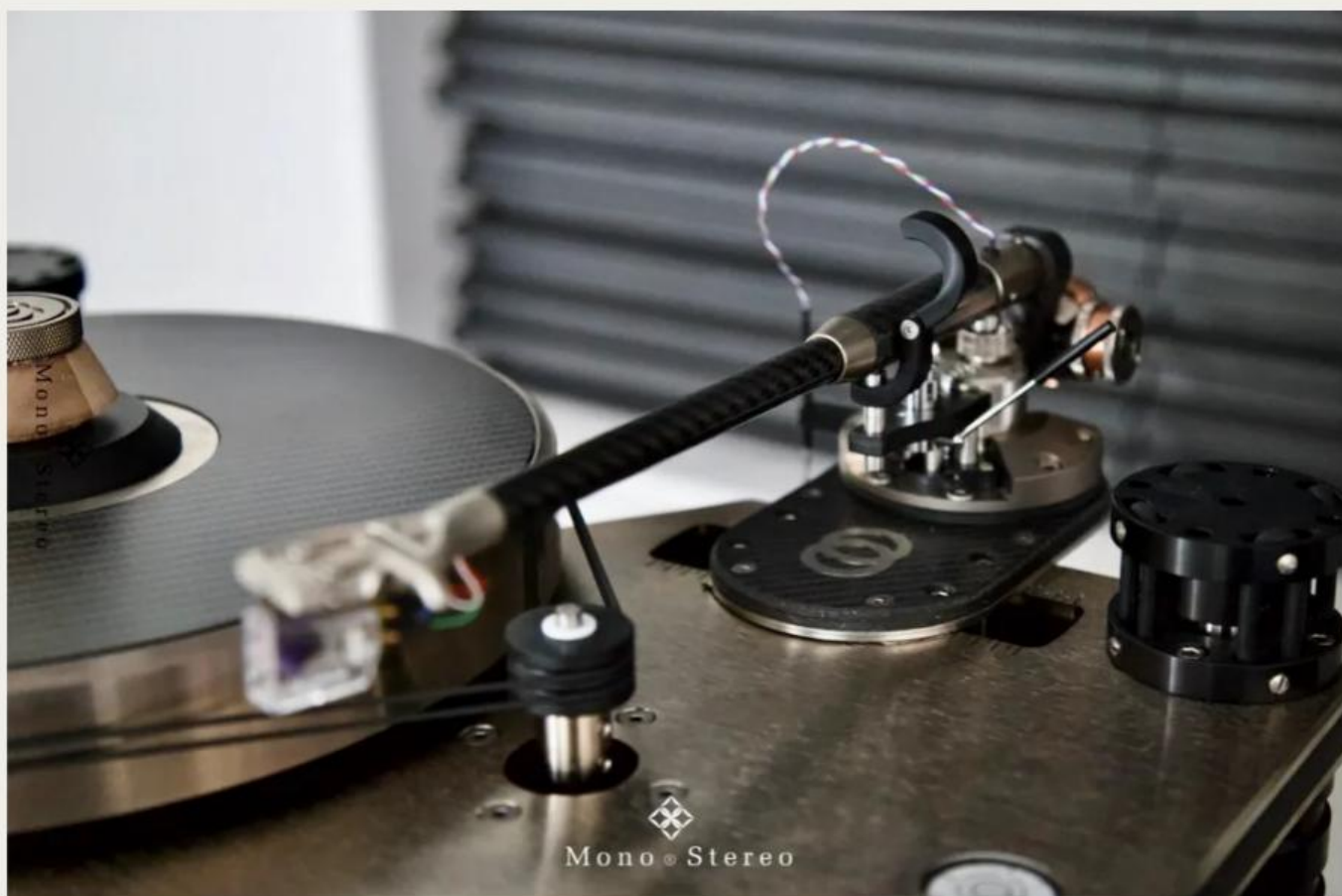




In any evaluation, the path for me is always clear and focused; to understand a level of intent, with the removal of any initial hyperbolespike of enthusiasm that usually subsides quickly.

More or less, with all high-end audio products, there is an obvious honeymoon phase, but with RS Discovery, the effect had not faded even after two weeks.

That is why I always point out that anything that is being seriously considered needs to be tested in a familiar room, with well-known reference components, and in front of the permanent loudspeaker choice.



Some tonearms (regardless of price) act as if the music is being sent through a filter, and just let the music leak through. In contrast, the Kronos Audio Discovery RS lets the music out and gives it room to breathe, immediately creating a balanced character and allowing the music's energy to come through unbridled.

With the Discovery RS, there are no kaleidoscopic sound collage phenomena. Kronos Audio's flagship tonearm behaves differently. It bundles everything, effortlessly controls the loud and quiet passages, and never lets the listener drown in the sound, but rather pulls them into the music stupendously well.



There's something fundamentally right about the Kronos Audio Discovery RS, which manifests itself in the fact that it doesn't disarray even and odd harmonics or dynamic fundamentals. This is especially evident with orchestral music, where some tonearms make it difficult to decipher the higher density of the mid and high frequencies and distinguish acoustic nodes and anchor points as the harmonics are closer together.



Like the Kronos Audio Pro turntable, the Discovery RS tonearm at no time behaves like a shoji screen, never demure decays and delays, and simply brings out more of what I like in analog music. Discovery RS shines with a steady yet fundamental difference in driving notes, the music reproduction is much more measured (but not mechanically sounding, precise, and most importantly lush. Discovery RS combines a loupe-like quality with the ability to encounter the music from a distance. ^

The combination of Kronos Pro turntable and Discovery RS tonearm simply hits parts of the brain where it doesn't have to translate anything unfamiliar, nor introduce analog jitter or mechanical hysteria.



There's little doubt, that Desjardins promulgated high-end audio vinyl in his path, and Discovery RS is an audacious piece of kit that continues and supports his bold endeavors.

The Kronoscope RS tonearm is no slouch performer, but Discovery RS takes its engaging character a step further, never letting the music fall apart or feel spastic, and ready at any time to assist and contribute as an elemental link of ultimate analog playback.



The Discovery RS tonearm, when paired with the Kronos Audio Pro turntable, provides a fertile analog combo ready to assist in the ultimate exploration of records, regal and lush, gelling everything, with a sublime potency and physical feeling differences.



As a part of the full Kronos Audio analog solution, Discovery RS represents a Mount Rushmore of vinyl playback and I am happy to grant it the Mono & Stereo 2023 Editors Choice Award. ❖



Price

- \$24,000 USD

Technical specifications

- Cartridge weight compatibility: 5 to 24 grams
- VTA adjustments: coarse and fine up to 1 inch
- Azimuth adjustment: Fine/Dual Counter Weights
- Bearing type: proprietary half ball and surface-treated elliptical dimpled uni-pivot receiving cup.
- Arm tube characteristics: Patented resonance suppressor technology. Multi-layered latticed reinforced composite arm tube.
- Head shell: Lazed precision ceramic composite with nickel cladding
- Cartridge plate: 5-point adjustable assembly, with variable resonance suppression tuning.
- Arm lift: hydraulic dampened, height adjustable.
- Shipping weight: 10kg
- Effective length: 306 mm
- Effective mass: medium high
- Overhang: 13.2 mm
- Pivot to spindle distance: 292 mm
- Maximum tracking error: 0.125
- measured resonant frequency (9 grams, 15 units of compliance test cartridge): 6.5 hertz

Contact

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